

Discussion of "Europe in the headlines"

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- Central questions: How visible is the EU? How does it relate to public perceptions?
- 400k articles (2005–2023) from over 100 French newspapers
- Combined Factiva with scraped Le Monde archives
- Relevance and polarity classified using Mistral 8x7B LLM
- Topic modeling with BERTopic
- Comparison with Eurobarometer responses (2005–2023)

Main Findings

- EU coverage is below 1% in total news, mostly event-driven (elections)
- Wide coverage of topic in international topics for National press (more negative)
- Local press emphasizes tangible EU benefits (Erasmus, CAP), often positively
- Sentiment in press dropped during crises, rebounded post-2013. Public opinion did not recover as much.

- Novel, large-scale dataset including local outlets
- Use of LLMs improves relevance and sentiment classification compared to dictionaries
- Insightful disaggregation (local/national, topic-level, personalities)
- Comparison with survey data captures dynamics missed in survey-based work

- Related to sample selection and LLM filtering: what is the EU?
- What exactly does "media sentiment" measure? Journalistic tone, topic salience, elite opinion?
- Press coverage may not a proxy for mass sentiment: it can lead, follow, or diverge. Worth discussing divergence with social media?
- Sentiment (pos vs neg) is assigned at article level: mixes voices and perspectives, hard to capture target.
- While nuanced by large collection of newspapers, literature might benefit from political communication (framing, visibility, elite cueing, agenda setting; e.g. Claes De Vreese on EU framing).

- Validation sample might be small (200 articles) given dataset size.
- Some descriptive count (normalized) of keywords between the excluded (58.9%) and the observed sample (41.1%) could further convince on LLM validation.
- Analysis on Factiva collection, contrary to many papers in this field. Not the collection, but also the composition matters. Maybe a robustness for the post 2013-divergence?

Empirical comments II

- As carefully discussed, is difficult to understand where the sentiment is directed. Why not exploiting sentiment scores by topic and their evolution over time?
- Sentiment **towards EU** is more negative, or EU appearing in negative events? (economic crisis etc)
- **Dynamic topic models** (Blei et al. 2006) could serve the purpose here:
 - Given how rich is your data, with 20 years of news, captures evolution of same topic (migration 2005 and 2011), and allow to relate sentiment as a function of topic prevalence.
 - With DTM you could quantify if topic shifts lead or lag opinion.
- The finding on discrepancy could be further analyzed by adding **robustness** (placebo) and **heterogeneity** (possible to decompose Eurobarometer by age, gender, education level?)

Possible extensions and follow up

- Explore causal effects linking media representation to turnout and voting?
- Connect with economic databases and parties agendas? (e.g. Euroskepticism from Manifesto project?)
- Moving beyond positive and negative: crisis and risk vs opportunity and strength?
- This could link to the literature on agenda setting, blame game, and EU integration through crisis.
- Comparison with social media?
- The methodological contribution is very promising, and extendable to other countries.